Analysis of Ibn al-Qayyim's Kitāb al-Rūḥ: Literary and Theological Dimensions

Executive Summary

The following briefing document synthesizes the literary analysis and historical context of *Kitāb al-Rūḥ* (The Book of the Spirit), authored by the 14th-century scholar Ibn al-Qayyim al-Jawziyya. Though widely considered a "best-seller" and a definitive text on Islamic views regarding the soul and spirit, recent scholarship suggests the work was left unfinished and is a composite of several independent essays.

Critical findings include:

- **Literary Complexity:** The text likely incorporates a "large book" (*kitābunā al-kabīr*) that Ibn al-Qayyim referenced in other works, particularly within the philosophical 19th query.
- **Authorship and Authenticity:** While its authenticity has been challenged by certain modern dogmatic circles (notably involving the late Grand Mufti Ibn Bāz), literary evidence and cross-references within Ibn al-Qayyim's other works strongly support his authorship.
- **Thematic Scope:** The work is structured into 21 "queries" (*masāʾil*) covering the metaphysics of the soul, the theology of the afterlife (the "punishment of the grave"), and moral philosophy.
- **Bibliographic Variance:** Significant discrepancies exist between the widely circulated Hyderabad printed editions and original manuscripts regarding the book's preface and title.

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1. Literary Composition and Structure

Analysis of *Kitāb al-Rūḥ* reveals a work that is exhaustive yet unpolished, suggesting it was not finalized for publication by Ibn al-Qayyim before his death in 1350.

The Theory of an Unfinished Work

Evidence suggests the book is a "vast repository" of information drawn from early sources, but it lacks the cohesive editing of a finished monograph.

- **Composite Nature:** The text appears to be a suture of several independent essays. For instance, the 21st query functions as a standalone treatise on morals, while the 19th query contains 100 proofs for the materiality of the soul—a discussion Ibn al-Qayyim refers to in other books as a separate, "large" work.

- **Internal Repetitions:** Queries 19 and 20 cover nearly identical ground regarding the distinction between *nafs* (soul) and *rūḥ* (spirit), which would likely have been merged in a final revision.

Structural Breakdown of the 21 Queries

The earliest manuscripts (e.g., Escorial 699) organize the queries into three distinct parts:

Part	Queries	Primary Subject Matter
I	1–16	The status and fate of the dead; awareness of the living; the "punishment of the grave."
II	17–18	The nature of the spirit; whether it is pre-eternal or created.
III	19–21	Philosophical definitions of the soul/spirit; moral psychology and the "three souls."

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2. Authenticity and Modern Debates

The authenticity of *Kitāb al-Rūḥ* has become a point of contention in modern Salafi scholarship, though these challenges appear to be motivated by dogmatic concerns rather than literary evidence.

- **Dogmatic Objections:** Some scholars, including followers of the late Sheikh Ibn Bāz, have questioned the book's authenticity because it endorses certain practices (such as Koran recitation at gravesites) that are viewed as "reprehensible innovations" by specific groups.
- **Defense of Authenticity:** Scholars such as Bakr Abū Zayd and Mashhūr Salmān have refuted these claims. They cite:
    - Numerous cross-references to *Kitāb al-Rūḥ* in Ibn al-Qayyim's other confirmed works (e.g., *Miftāḥ dār al-saʿāda* and *al-Tabyīn*).
    - Direct citations of Ibn al-Qayyim's master, Ibn Taymiyya, within the text.
    - The existence of manuscripts dating to within one generation of the author's death (e.g., Escorial 1590, dated 798/1395–1396).

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3. Bibliographic History and Manuscripts

The transmission of *Kitāb al-Rūḥ* is characterized by a reliance on a single printing lineage that may not represent the author's original intent.

The Hyderabad Legacy

Nearly all modern printings derive from the original Hyderabad issue (1318/1900–1901). This version includes a preface that was likely added by Burhān al-Dīn al-Biqāʿī (d. 1480), who also provided the title *Sirr al-rūḥ* (The Secret of the Soul). Ibn al-Qayyim himself may never have formally titled the work; it became known as *Kitāb al-Rūḥ* due to its subject matter.

Manuscript Evidence

Original manuscripts found in European and American libraries (Escorial, Leiden, Vienna, Princeton, British Library) offer a different perspective:

- **Authentic Preface:** Manuscripts in the Escorial and Leiden collections contain a first-person introduction by Ibn al-Qayyim. This preface focuses on Koran 23:12–14, detailing the stages of human creation—a theme consistent with the Ḥanbalī school's defense against heretical claims of Koranic inconsistency.
- **Early Witnesses:** The Escorial 1590 manuscript is the earliest dated exemplar, copied just decades after the author's demise.

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4. Key Philosophical and Theological Themes

The document serves as a foundational statement for the "corporeal school" of orthodox Islam regarding the spirit.

The Nature of the Soul (*Nafs*) vs. Spirit (*Rūḥ*)

Ibn al-Qayyim attempts to synthesize scientific, philosophical, and religious meanings of these terms.

- **Entity vs. Accident:** He argues against the Aristotelian view that the soul is merely an "accident" of the body. Instead, he asserts that the spirit is a "self-standing entity" that is luminous, supernal, and capable of movement (rising and descending) independent of the physical body.
- **Creation:** He maintains a firm line that the spirit is a created entity, rejecting doctrines of pre-eternality as heretical.

The Three Souls

The final section of the book explores the three traditional psychological states mentioned in Islamic tradition:

1. **Al-ammāra:** The soul that commands evil.
2. **Al-lawwāma:** The self-reproaching or rebuking soul.

3. **Al-muṭmaʾinna:** The serene or tranquil soul. The analysis of these states evolves into a broader treatise on morals, distinguishing between laudable and disgraceful human traits (e.g., the difference between self-respect and conceit).

Interaction Between the Living and Dead

The book provides extensive traditional evidence for:

- The awareness of the dead regarding the visits and greetings of the living.
- The meeting of spirits of the living with spirits of the dead (often in dreams).
- The benefits the deceased may derive from the prayers and good works of those still living.

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5. Scholarly Significance

Kitāb al-Rūḥ remains essential for understanding the "creative religious thought of Islam." As noted by 20th-century scholars D.B. Macdonald and Francis T. Cooke, the views expressed in this book represent the belief of the vast majority of Muslims. It serves as a bridge between early medieval scientific/philosophical inquiries and the established orthodoxy of the Ḥanbalī and subsequent Wahhābī traditions.